it does not surrender to force.[53]

James Tod, Rajput-manqué, tells a similar tale. According to him, Kunwar Man Singh, Harkha Bai's nineteen-year-old nephew, went to Ranthambore to negotiate with Rai Surjan. The two Rajput royals sat and conversed, while Man Singh's mace-bearer stood behind him, quiet and unnoticed. As the negotiations dragged on, Rai Surjan's uncle's eyes drifted to Man Singh's attendant.

The uncle sprang up – this was no mace-bearer, it was Akbar! The elder Rajput took the mace from the young king's hands, and offered him a cushion. Unfazed, Akbar sat down and said, 'Well, Rao Soorjun, what is to be done?'[54]

Rai Surjan was king of Bundi and pledged allegiance, like many kings of Rajasthan, to the rana of Mewar, in this case his cousin, in whose name, in fact, Surjan held Ranthambore. Akbar's proposal was that Rai Surjan transfer his allegiance from Mewar to the Mughal; in return, he would be made an honoured commander in Akbar's court, with fifty-two districts to rule as he would and the liberty to name his terms.

The idea would not have sounded foreign to Rajput ears. It was an established tradition of Rajput lords to have dependent clients called '*chakars*'. The term, writes Norman Ziegler, 'carries the general meaning of servant, but in Marwari usage, designates a "military retainer", one who held rights over villages on the condition of provision of arms to a superior, or who was included as a member of his patron's personal household'.[55] These were essentially the terms, if on a grander scale, that Rai Surjan was being asked to consider.

Eventually, the rai agreed, though with conditions. The first of these, writes Tod, was that no bridal procession would ever leave Bundi for Akbar's harem.

The authenticity of this treaty is disputed; but if, indeed, the king of Bundi insisted on a frosty barrier between his political alliance and the implied honour of his blood, Akbar seems to have shrugged it off. Alauddin Khilji, the thirteenth-century emperor with whom Abul Fazl often compares Akbar's achievements, had taken a whole year to break Ranthambore 'with great difficulty';[56] Akbar had done it in just over a month. In the spring of 1569, Akbar rode into the grand fortress and raised his banners from its